



PRESENTED TO THE CITY OF WILMINGTON — OFFICE OF ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

Office of Economic Development · April 2026

Four Asks. One Aligned Strategy.

A coordinated proposal pairing the Merge4Ward sustainable manufacturing initiative with the M4Di Operational Intelligence platform — and a pathway to evolve the City's existing A&E Feasibility Assistance program into a regional cost-credibility standard. No new City programs required. Every existing OED tool already fits.

► TIME-CRITICAL: OED letter requested by May 1, 2026 · Wells Fargo / Enterprise application deadline May 15, 2026

Merge4Ward LLC · Merge 4 Design LLC (M4D) · M4Di™ — Merge 4 Development Institute

· Aubyn Architecture LLC · L.E.E.P., Inc. · Central Baptist CDC

\$2M x 2

Two coordinated Wells Fargo / Enterprise Housing Affordability Breakthrough Challenge applications. Submission deadline May 15, 2026.

\$15K

Current A&E Feasibility Assistance ceiling. M4Di adds independent verification at \$3.5K–\$6.5K — without changing the existing program structure.

22-35

Year-3 manufacturing jobs at the Port — Merge4Ward CLT/SIP production. Wage tax base inside the Strategic Fund's 2–3 year recoup window.

5

Existing OED programs the HQ ask is built around: Strategic Fund, Property Tax Abatement, DDD, Head Tax Exemption, A&E Feasibility Assistance.

A Documented Cost-Credibility Gap. A Working Solution. A 14-Day Decision Window.

The City of Wilmington has a quiet but well-documented predevelopment cost-credibility problem that affects every funded project the Office of Economic Development touches. The A&E Feasibility Assistance grant, the Strategic Fund, the DDD rebate, and the Property Tax Abatement program all make commitments downstream against early-stage construction estimates of varying — and unverified — quality. When those estimates collapse during construction documentation or after permit, the City has already absorbed program cost and lost the project.

Merge 4 Design and M4Di have spent the last eighteen months building the methodology, the platform, and the local partnerships that close that gap. We arrive at this meeting with one coherent strategy, four entry points, and zero requests for new City appropriation. Every ask routes through OED programs that already exist.

What Wilmington OED Receives

- ▶ A coordinated \$4M federal grant push — two applications, one City letter — with measurable Year-3 wage-tax return inside the Strategic Fund's recoup window
- ▶ An independent, architect-led cost-verification standard for the A&E Feasibility Assistance grant — protecting every downstream OED program decision
- ▶ A vacant Wilmington building put back into productive use as a multi-firm professional services anchor — three named brands at one address
- ▶ A documented economic development case study: City programs stacked correctly on a tenant who actually uses them
- ▶ A growing proprietary regional cost benchmark dataset (the M4Di ALDDB) that becomes the City's own standing reference for what construction in Wilmington really costs

What the State of Delaware Wins Alongside

- ▶ First-of-state CLT/SIP hybrid manufacturing operation in Delaware — the Claymont pilot is the foundation case
- ▶ DEDO Strategic Fund leverage at the Port — manufacturing jobs paying \$22–\$34/hr against state grants of \$250K–\$1M
- ▶ EPA Brownfields and EDA Public Works alignment on Site A scenarios — federal capital flowing through Wilmington toward state economic development priorities
- ▶ L.E.E.P. workforce training pipeline — 80–120 Delaware-resident graduates per cycle by Year 3 across CLT/SIP production roles
- ▶ A regional predevelopment cost intelligence standard **headquartered in Wilmington**, with the City as its first municipal partner

One Strategy. Four Entry Points. Sequential — Not Parallel.

The asks are presented in meeting order. Ask 1 is time-critical with a hard May 1 letter deadline. Ask 2 is the relationship-defining ask. Asks 3 and 4 are the structural commitments that anchor everything that follows.

ASK 1 · URGENT Letter of Support – Wells Fargo / Enterprise Grant Two coordinated \$2M applications by May 15. Merge4Ward (Design & Construction). M4Di OI Tool (Service & Delivery, via CB CDC). OED letter materially affects scoring.	ASK 2 · STRATEGIC M4Di as OED's Cost Verification Standard Position M4Di as the cost-intelligence benchmark for the A&E Feasibility Assistance grant and the Strategic Fund. Pilot engagement on 3–5 funded projects in FY26.	ASK 3 · STRUCTURAL Site Identification – Merge4Ward Manufacturing Port-adjacent industrial parcel, 1–6 acres. City-controlled or City-facilitated land. Letter of intent within 60 days for inclusion in EDA grant stack.	ASK 4 · ANCHOR M4D / Aubyn Headquarters – Vacant Building Match 4,000–8,000 SF vacant warehouse or light-industrial building. Fitted out as client-facing HQ. Stacked on Strategic Fund + Property Tax Abatement + DDD where eligible.
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SECTION 3 – ASK 1

Letter of Support – Enterprise / Wells Fargo Housing Affordability Breakthrough Challenge

The 2026 Housing Affordability Breakthrough Challenge — managed by Enterprise Community Partners and funded by Wells Fargo — will award five \$2M grants (\$10M total) to ready-to-scale solutions. Applications close May 15, 2026. We are filing two coordinated applications under two of the three eligible categories. Both pull from work already underway in Wilmington.

APPLICATION 1 · DESIGN & CONSTRUCTION

Merge4Ward – CLT/SIP Manufacturing

Merge4Ward LLC is a forming SIP/CLT manufacturing company anchored by a partnership between Merge 4 Design and L.E.E.P., Inc. (Gwen Motley, Executive Director). The Claymont CLT/SIP hybrid townhouse pilot — 4 units, \$1.875M ROM, foundation permit imminent, panels arriving May 27 — is the proof-of-concept.

First-of-state CLT/SIP hybrid application in Delaware. The grant funds Phase 1 launch: leased facility, equipment procurement, first production run, first L.E.E.P. workforce training cohort.

For-profit eligible under Design & Construction. No nonprofit lead applicant required.

APPLICATION 2 · SERVICE & DELIVERY PROGRAMS

M4Di OI Tool – Cost Intelligence Platform

The M4Di Operational Intelligence Tool is a regionally calibrated predevelopment cost intelligence platform — architect-led, methodology-grounded — currently in active deployment on Central Baptist CDC's two-site feasibility engagement, funded by Sea Change Capital Partners.

Lead applicant: Central Baptist CDC (Dr. Rev. Keeling presiding) under M4Di's existing fiscal sponsorship structure. Funds the Phase 1 web application build and regional deployment to CDFIs, faith-based developers, and community land trusts across the Mid-Atlantic.

Service & Delivery requires a 501(c)(3) nonprofit lead. CB CDC fits cleanly.

WHY THE OED LETTER MOVES THE NEEDLE

Past Breakthrough Challenge scoring has weighted demonstrated municipal alignment heavily. A Wilmington OED letter referencing the existing A&E Feasibility Assistance program and the Strategic Fund — and stating that M4Di's methodology is being evaluated for adoption as the City's cost-verification standard — is direct evidence to the panel that the City has skin in the game. Without that signal, the

applications read as private-sector innovations seeking validation. With it, they read as proven municipal partnerships ready to scale. **TWO READY-TO-SIGN DRAFT LETTERS ARE ATTACHED TO THIS BRIEF FOR OED'S REVIEW AND EDIT.**

SECTION 4 – ASK 2

Adopt the M4Di OI Tool as OED's Cost Verification Standard

The DBE A&E Feasibility Assistance program offers a 50% match up to \$15,000 to enumerate construction costs for Wilmington projects. The program's structural design is correct. What it currently lacks — and what M4Di provides — is a standardized, independent, regionally calibrated verification layer that protects every downstream OED commitment.

TODAY'S WORKFLOW	RISK PROFILE	WHAT'S MISSING
DBE applicant secures A&E firm. 50% match up to \$15K. Estimate produced.	Variable quality. Methodology unknown. Sometimes produced by the GC who would build the project.	Independent verification
Strategic Fund / DDD / Property Tax Abatement decisions made downstream.	Decisions stack on the same unverified estimate.	Regional calibration
Project enters CD phase. Real bids arrive.	Budget collapses on a meaningful share of community-development projects nationally.	A growing benchmark dataset
WITH M4Di OI TOOL VERIFICATION	Independent. Standardized. Methodology documented.	All three resolved

M4Di does not replace the A&E firm or the existing program. It adds a parallel, independent verification layer at \$3,500–\$6,500 per project — well below the \$15,000 program ceiling.

PILOT STRUCTURE
– FY26

**3–5 Projects.
One Quarter
to Prove the
Model.**

Per project:
Independent Gate O ROM with regional calibration narrative, gate report, and reconciliation against the applicant's submitted estimate. Two-page summary suitable for OED program file.

Cost to OED:
\$3,500–\$6,500 per engagement.

Outputs:
Standardized cost reports. Aggregate annual benchmark data for OED's internal use. Quarterly review.

Year 2: Convert pilot to standing OED engagement. Add Strategic Fund and DDD applications. M4Di publishes the **Wilmington Predevelopment Cost Index** annually.

THE FRAMING THAT WILL LAND

The A&E Feasibility Assistance program is the right idea. M4Di is the natural infrastructure under it. **FICO DID NOT REPLACE MORTGAGE UNDERWRITING – IT STANDARDIZED THE CREDIT SIGNAL THAT MORTGAGE UNDERWRITING DEPENDED ON.** M4Di does the same thing for predevelopment cost. OED becomes the first municipality in the Mid-Atlantic to formalize a cost-credibility standard for community development projects — and the precedent it sets is exportable to every peer city in the region.

SECTION 5 – ASK 3

Site Identification – Merge4Ward Manufacturing

Merge4Ward Phase 1 requires 1–6 acres of industrial land for SIP press operations, CLT staging and cutting, and L.E.E.P. workforce training. Phase 1 building footprint is approximately 30,000–45,000 SF. Port adjacency is strongly preferred — it reduces transportation cost on raw timber inputs and unlocks regional export potential by water.

VARIABLE	SITE A – EXISTING INDUSTRIAL	SITE B – CITY-CONTROLLED PORT PARCEL
Acreage	4–6 acres with existing building shell	1–2 acres, new construction required
Construction cost	Lower – fitout of existing shell	Higher by \$800K–\$1.4M – pre-engineered metal building
Timeline to operations	Faster (existing building)	6–12 months longer
Brownfield potential	Yes – EPA Brownfields grant eligible (\$200K–\$500K)	No – clean parcel
Political path	Private seller negotiation	Direct OED engagement – fastest agency path

YEAR 3 · PERMANENT JOBS

22–35 Manufacturing Roles

CNC operators, panel assembly technicians, QC inspectors, dispatch and logistics. Average wage \$26–\$34/hr by Year 3. All accessible without a four-year degree. L.E.E.P. trains the pipeline.

YEAR 3 · WORKFORCE PIPELINE

80–120 L.E.E.P. Graduates / Cycle

Two cohorts per year by Phase 3. CLT/SIP production track plus building science fundamentals. Delaware residents trained for Delaware-headquartered employers.

YEAR 3 · TAX BASE

\$220K–\$380K / Year

State and local tax contribution from Merge4Ward operations alone. Inside the Strategic Fund's documented 2–3 year recoup window — the deal the Fund was designed to underwrite.

STRATEGIC FUND ALIGNMENT

The City of Wilmington Strategic Fund recoups incentive expenditures within two to three years through wage taxes from new or retained jobs. Merge4Ward's Year-1 wage-tax contribution alone — 12–18 manufacturing jobs at \$22–\$28/hour — falls squarely inside the Strategic Fund's recoup window. **THIS IS EXACTLY THE DEAL THE STRATEGIC FUND WAS DESIGNED TO UNDERWRITE.**

SECTION 6 — ASK 4

M4D / Aubyn Headquarters – A Vacant Wilmington Building, Brought Back to Life

The M4D book of business now includes capital projects with M-Well Medical Group (\$76M campus), Wilmington Housing Authority (1212 Lobdel Avenue), L.E.E.P., Inc. (Claymont pilot), Culture Restoration Project (Monroe Street church adaptive reuse), and an active client conversation pipeline across the predevelopment platform. These conversations require a client-facing space that signals scale and seriousness — investor briefings, capital-stack working sessions, multi-party design reviews, and live OI Tool demonstrations.

We are asking OED to point us at a vacant warehouse, light-industrial, or commercial building (4,000–8,000 SF) in Wilmington that the City has interest in seeing brought back into productive use.

ZONE 1

Open Studio

Design and BIM production. Travis-led visualization workflow — Revit, Bonsai, FLUX. Daily working environment.

ZONE 2

Investor Lounge

Client-facing conference room with full AV — multi-source video, projection, audio for hybrid meetings, secure network.

ZONE 3

M4Di Demo Station

Live OI Tool, ALDi Tracker, and Terminal walkthrough station for funder, CDFI, and municipal client visits.

ZONE 4

Material Library

CLT/SIP component display, architectural samples, modest archive. A space the City can co-host events in.

OED / CITY PROGRAM	TYPE	HOW IT APPLIES TO THE HQ BUILD
City of Wilmington Strategic Fund	Local Incentive	Job-creation incentive against the four Wilmington-based principal positions plus 1–2 hires planned in FY26. Recoup window aligns with Strategic Fund design.
Property Tax Abatement (Sec. 44-71)	Local Incentive	Applies to fitout investment if the building qualifies as commercial, mixed-use, or multi-family rehabilitation.

OED / CITY PROGRAM	TYPE	HOW IT APPLIES TO THE HQ BUILD
Downtown Development District (DDD)	Local + State	If the property falls inside a designated DDD, our Qualified Real Property Investment for fitout may rebate up to 20% via DSHA.
Head Tax Exemption	Local Incentive	Applicable to net new hires at the HQ location.
Opportunity Zone (if located in OZ)	Federal	Applies to investor capital placed in the project — relevant if outside expansion capital is brought in.
A&E Feasibility Assistance (DBE)	Local Grant	Aubyn Architecture LLC is a DBE-eligible firm with the technical capability to apply matched funds well.

WHAT THIS RETURNS TO THE CITY

A vacant Wilmington building put back into productive use. Three named brand-active firms operating from a single Wilmington address — visible, marketable, photographable for OED's own success-stories pipeline. A professionally fitted-out venue the City can co-host events at: DBE roundtables, A&E feasibility cohort meetings, workforce-development announcements. **OED ALREADY HAS THE TOOLS. WE ARE ASKING OED TO POINT THEM AT THE RIGHT VACANT BUILDING.**

SECTION 7 — WHY THESE ASKS BELONG TOGETHER

Three Horizons. Returns Compound at Each.

90 DAYS • 2026 – NOW Letter, Site Shortlist, Pilot May 1 letter • May 15 grant deadlines OED letter delivered. Site shortlist active. HQ candidate buildings under review. Pilot M4Di engagement begins on first FY26 A&E Feasibility project. Two grant applications submitted with City endorsement.	12 MONTHS • 2027 Awards Land. HQ Operational. Strategic Fund deal closed Wilmington named in any awarded grants. First Strategic Fund deal closed for HQ tenant. M4Di pilot data report delivered to OED. Manufacturing site secured. M4Di OI Tool deployed on 3–5 funded City projects.	36 MONTHS • 2029 Standard-Setting Anchor Self-sustaining Manufacturing operations producing for affordable housing pipeline. 22–35 permanent jobs at the Port. M4Di adopted as City cost-verification standard. HQ established as DBE/A&E case study. Wilmington Predevelopment Cost Index published annually.	BEYOND • 2030+ Regional Export Licensing & affiliate M4Di expanded across Mid-Atlantic with Wilmington as anchor reference site. Cooperative conversion underway at Merge4Ward. Municipal cost-verification standard exported to peer cities — Wilmington gets the precedent credit.
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Four Steps. Each Maps to an Existing OED Tool.

- **Step 1 — Letter of Support by May 1 (URGENT):** A letter from OED endorsing both Wells Fargo / Enterprise applications — Merge4Ward (Design & Construction) and the M4Di OI Tool via Central Baptist CDC (Service & Delivery). Two ready-to-sign drafts are attached to this brief for OED to review and edit with the Mayor's office.
- **Step 2 — M4Di Pilot on 3–5 FY26 A&E Feasibility Projects:** A pilot engagement positioning M4Di as the cost-verification layer beneath the existing A&E Feasibility Assistance program. \$3,500–\$6,500 per project. Standardized outputs, aggregate annual benchmark data, quarterly review.
- **Step 3 — Site Identification for Merge4Ward Manufacturing:** Identification of City-controlled or City-facilitated parcels in the Port corridor matching the Phase 1 footprint (1–6 acres). Letter of interest within 60 days for inclusion in the Breakthrough Challenge application and the EDA grant stack.
- **Step 4 — HQ Vacant Building Match:** A vacant warehouse, light-industrial, or commercial building (4,000–8,000 SF) brought to our attention. Stack Strategic Fund + Property Tax Abatement + DDD where eligible. We become the OED case study used in the next ten conversations like this one.

Two Adjacent Opportunities the Meeting Did Not Have Time to Cover

Both items below were prepared for the meeting but deferred for time. They are presented here for OED's awareness and as conversation points for a follow-up session — not as additional asks against the four already on the table. Both directly extend the strategy already discussed.

HORIZON ITEM 1 · ANCHOR / SIGNATURE PROJECT

Riverfront East, Parcel B — A First-of-State CLT/SIP Public Pavilion

RDC's **Parcel B** sits at the bend of the Christina River, eminently visible from Riverfront West, and is described in the Riverfront East public materials as "an anchor point at the bend in the river" and "a chance for striking retail presence — or whatever your vision holds." The 0.19-acre parcel with a 3,019 SF parcel limit is well-matched to a single-volume CLT/SIP timber pavilion.

Our concept — and we want to underscore that this is a concept stage, not a proposal — is an **open-air farmers market and entertainment pavilion** built with Merge4Ward-produced CLT structural panels and SIP roof assemblies. A first-of-state demonstration of regional sustainable timber manufacturing in a civic, public-facing form. It would visibly mark Wilmington as the East Coast's earliest mover on regional CLT supply, while delivering a permanent public amenity at the most visible point on Riverfront East.

Parcel: 0.19 acres, 3,019 SF parcel limit, 109 ft frontage

Owner / Steward: Riverfront Development Corporation of Delaware

Ask of OED (future): Facilitated introduction to RDC (Megan McGlinchey, Executive Director). City-RDC alignment around a Phase-2 anchor concept.

HORIZON ITEM 2 · SPECIFIC HQ CANDIDATE

1601 Jessup Street — A Brandywine HQ Candidate, Already Identified

In addition to the general HQ ask in Section 6, we have identified a specific candidate property worth OED's evaluation. **1601 Jessup Street** (Parcel #2602930259) is a 0.15-acre Brandywine peninsula site with an existing brick light-manufacturing building (~8,706 SF + secondary structures), ample asphalt parking already in place, and existing perimeter security fencing.

The site offers downstream views of the Wilmington skyline — making it an unusually well-suited **client-facing HQ and marketing lounge** for M4D, Aubyn Architecture, M4Di, and Merge4Ward. The architectural intervention required is modest: open the riverside elevation, frame the view, refresh the interior to studio + investor lounge + M4Di demo configuration. The brick industrial character is the asset, not the obstacle.

Parcel: 0.15 acres, 30 ft frontage × 89.30 ft depth, ~8,700 SF main building

Zoning: Currently classified Light Manufacturing — Waterfront Res/Comm overlay; City Chapter 48 zoning to be confirmed

Ask of OED (future): Confirm ownership status and any City interest. Evaluate as Ask 4 candidate against Strategic Fund + Property Tax Abatement stack.

The Team Behind This Proposal

Merge 4 Design LLC

Architecture · Design ·

Predevelopment Intelligence

Knight · Ainsworth · Lynch · Davis

Aubyn Architecture LLC

Architecture · AOR

David C. Ainsworth, AIA · DE/PA/CT

M4Di™

Predevelopment Cost Intelligence

CB CDC fiscal sponsorship

Merge4Ward LLC

Manufacturing entity · Wilmington,

DE

Ainsworth · Motley · Knight · Lynch

· Davis

L.E.E.P., Inc.

Community Developer · 501(c)(3)

Gwenevere Motley · Wilmington, DE

Central Baptist CDC

501(c)(3) · Service & Delivery lead

Dr. Rev. Keeling

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On behalf of the Merge 4 Design partnership: **Trevor Knight** (GMD), **Leo Lynch** (Operations), **Travis Davis**
(Delivery).

Attached: (A) Draft Letter of Support — Merge4Ward / Design & Construction. (B) Draft Letter of Support —
M4Di OI Tool / Service & Delivery via Central Baptist CDC.